

Psychologist making a difference:

There may be at least three ways through which psychology and psychologists can contribute to peace processes:

1. Psychological research findings can be useful for peace processes.
2. Psychologists as a professional group can involve in negotiations or other peace-related processes.
3. Applied psychological counseling skills such as active listening, basic empathy, multicultural competency, acceptance, rapport-building etc. can be utilized to train both sides of the conflict for a smooth transition to peace processes. Unfortunately, these three options are rarely taken into consideration. The article discusses various ways through which psychology and psychologists can and can't contribute to peace processes, errors, biases and fallacies typically observed in the relevant research and the applied fields, and the distinction between medical and social models of peace.

Introduction: theoretical problems with the notions of peace and peace psychology

Definitions of peace psychology (Christie et al., 2001:8):

Peace psychology seeks to develop theories and practices aimed at the prevention and mitigation of direct and structural violence. Framed positively, peace psychology promotes the nonviolent management of conflict and the pursuit of social justice, what we refer to as peacemaking and peacebuilding, respectively.

Contrary to the common sense view, conflicts are not always negative. For one thing, social history progresses through conflicts and contradictions. So peace psychology does not aim to end the conflicts, but manage them. That means, even after a successful peace process, the conflict will exist, but it will be at a manageable level. Otherwise, if the aim of peace psychology would be to completely end the conflicts, we had to assimilate one ethnic group into another, forcibly converting a party to become another, e.g. from Christianity to Islam and vice versa. Thus, peace does not mean to have people similar to each other, but continue to be different; different but no longer in non-manageable forms of conflict. Christie (2011) makes a useful distinction between direct peace and structural peace referring to a number of pioneering studies in peace psychology, and accordingly between peacemaking and peacebuilding. The former corresponds to physical confrontation, while the latter refers to structural forms of violence. Peacemaking accordingly has more to do with ceasefire, while peacebuilding is more long-term oriented.

Peace psychologists are not only developing theories and practices aimed at the prevention of direct violence, but are also working to mitigate structural violence, which means the reduction of hierarchical relations within and between societies. Hierarchical relations privilege those on the top while oppressing, exploiting, and dominating those on the bottom. Framed positively, we can conceptualize peacebuilding as movement toward social justice which occurs when political structures become more inclusive by giving voice to those who have been marginalized in decisions that affect their well-being, and economic structures become transformed so that those who have been exploited gain greater access to material resources that satisfy their basic needs

Contribution of psychological research findings for peace processes Biases in naming and formulating the conflict

Being a peace psychologist in research and especially in practice necessitates identifying our own biases, blind spots and any other subjectivity that can sabotage peace efforts from the very beginning.

Fallacy of analysis without institutions for peace building,

We need transformations in social institutions such as media, education, justice, military etc. However, popular discussions on mainstream media usually ignore this. For mainstream media, the key point is not peace building as such, but ceasefire. They often confuse ceasefire with peace. Most of the social psychology research on peacemaking is flawed, as war and peace are not sustained by group processes, but by pro-war vs. pro-peace institutions. If it has nothing to do with group processes, the solution can't be in changing group-related variables. A typical example of an institutional influence can be seen in the role of mass communication in Nazi atrocities and pro-war radio programs in Rwanda that led to massacres. Radios can also be used to foster peace.

An institutional psychology is needed for peace

Following from the previous point, psychological research not referring to individual or group cognition only, but investigating the relationship between pro-war and pro-peace institutions and individual/group cognition is needed. For example, one reason peace can't be built in a country is political immunity and impunity in cases of state terrorism. Research on peace psychology and state terrorism is virtually non-existent. If somebody kills a man/woman, he is punished; but if state officials kill somebody, sometimes they can go away with it. Even if we can teach people to be more peaceful, such impunity perpetuates state terrorism. The true questions would be about how this impunity affects people's behavior, and to what extent the norms set by institutions such as a justice system which rarely distributes justice in acts of state terrorism affect the citizens. Without taking institutions into account, the way mainstream psychology studies peace is analogous to the following situation: Suppose that we still have slavery, but psychology studies cognitions about slavery rather than the social, material and institutional foundations of slavery. The end of racism does not necessarily end slavery. From the other direction, racism didn't end when the governments abolished slavery, but without institutional abolishment declarations, the end of slavery was not even possible. In other words, official change in social norms with regard to slavery was a necessary, but not a sufficient condition for the end of slavery.

Limited external validity of social psychology experiments on peace and war

Social psychology experiments on peace and war come up with sound findings; however whether they are applicable on society as a whole is problematic. That is because people in laboratory settings do not necessarily behave naturally. They are in the knowledge that they are in an experiment, they are isolated from social influences that exert power on their cognitions and behaviors in real life, and the effects created in the experiments are not necessarily lasting. Furthermore, institutions can't be represented in experiments with all their power in real life. For example, students can be made more peaceful and ready to apologize for crimes committed by their in-groups etc. in experimental settings, but when they join the compulsory military service, a strong institutional setting, all these gains will be gone.

